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3

THE INDIAN CONCEPT OF SELF

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3.1 INTRODUCTION

The question “Who am I?” is both profoundly simple and infinitely complex. From early childhood, human beings begin to form a sense of self—first through bodily awareness, then through social interactions, language, and memory. A toddler pointing to themselves in the mirror, a school-age child describing their favourite subject, or an adolescent grappling with identity and purpose—all reflect the gradual construction of the self. But are we sure that the answer we receive is the explanation of the Self?

Who am I? The question is age-old and there is a clash of understanding between philosophical and psychological exploration for centuries. In psychology, the Self is often defined in terms of identity, personality, cognition, and social roles—how we perceive ourselves, how others see us, and how we behave in various contexts. For example, a child might see himself/herself as a student, a daughter, or a friend, forming a sense of self through interaction, feedback, and experience. However, Indian philosophy invites us to look beyond these

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changing roles and experiences to ask: *Is there something deeper, more constant beneath these labels?* Traditions such as Vedānta, Sāṃkhya, Buddhism, and Jainism offer diverse yet profound answers, exploring the Self not merely as a psychological construct, but as a spiritual or metaphysical reality. These perspectives suggest that the essence of who we are may lie beyond the body and mind—in consciousness, pure awareness, or even in the absence of a permanent self.

This deeper inquiry into the Self is not merely metaphysical; it has practical implications for education, child development, and mental well-being. For instance, when children learn to observe their thoughts or regulate emotions through practices like mindfulness or yoga—rooted in Indian traditions—they begin to access a part of themselves that is beyond mere reaction or performance. In these moments, the Self is not just “how I appear” or “what I do,” but “what I truly am”—a realization that can foster resilience, empathy, and ethical grounding.

Moreover, the Indian view encourages a relational and spiritual understanding of the Self. Rather than viewing identity in isolation—as is often emphasized in Western models of selfhood—Indian systems often present the Self as interconnected with others, nature, and the cosmos. The Upanishadic idea that “Tat Tvam Asi” (Thou art That) reflects a vision in which the individual self is not separate from the universe, but a reflection of it. This stands in contrast to the more individualistic constructs of selfhood common in Western psychology.

In educational settings, acknowledging this broader, more integrated view of the Self can profoundly influence how we understand children’s growth. If we view development not just as acquiring skills or forming a social identity, but as a journey toward inner awareness and balance, our educational aims shift accordingly. The classroom becomes not only a space for knowledge transmission, but also for self-discovery, ethical inquiry, and emotional maturation.

This chapter explores these rich Indian viewpoints, aiming to bridge philosophical insight with contemporary understandings of child development. By integrating these perspectives, educators and psychologists can foster a more holistic and culturally grounded understanding of how children come to know themselves and their place in the world.



3.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- distinguishes between self, identity, and concept of self;
- explains the roles of Mind, Intellect, and Memory;
- describes and relates to the five layers of Panch-koshīya Vikas and their role in holistic human development;
- analyses concept of Self and applies it;
- states the role of Indian society in the development of Self.

3.3 UNDERSTANDING OF SELF, IDENTITY AND SELF-CONCEPT IN INDIAN CONTEXT

The timeless questions “Who am I?” (expressed as *koham* in Sanskrit) and “Who are you?” (*kastvam*) have been asked for centuries in Indian philosophy. These questions go beyond simple curiosity—they encourage us to think deeply about our identity, our inner nature, and how we see ourselves and others. In modern terms, they relate closely to ideas like self-awareness, self-concept, and personal identity, which are important not only in psychology but also in education. As teachers, understanding how children develop a sense of who they are can help us support their emotional growth, confidence, and learning in meaningful ways.

In Indian philosophy, understanding the self is foundational to both metaphysical inquiry and spiritual practice. However, it is important to distinguish between three interrelated but distinct ideas: Self (*Ātman*), Identity, and Self-concept.

3.3.1 Concept of Self

The *Ātman* is considered the eternal, unchanging reality at the core of every individual. It is pure consciousness, unaffected by the body, mind, or any external conditions. According to systems like Advaita Vedānta, realizing the *Ātman* as non-different from Brahman (the ultimate reality) is the highest goal of life—*mokṣa* or liberation. The *Ātman* is beyond dualities, unaffected by karma, and is the witness (*sākṣin*) of all experiences.

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3.3.2 Concept of Identity

In contrast, identity refers to the social and empirical labels one adopts or is assigned—such as name, gender, caste, profession, and family role. These arise from one's body, circumstances, and social order (varṇa-āśrama dharma). Indian philosophical systems like Sāṃkhya and Vedānta view these identities as part of the ego (ahaṅkāra)—a false sense of self created by ignorance. Identities are changeable and perish with the body.

3.3.3 Concept of Self-Concept

Self-concept is a more internal, psychological understanding—how one perceives and evaluates oneself. It includes thoughts like “I am capable,” “I am spiritual,” or “I am flawed.” In Indian thought, this arises from the mind and intellect (manas and buddhi), shaped by past experiences (saṃskāras) and desires (vāsanās). Though more introspective than identity, self-concept is still not the true self, and must be transcended on the path to liberation.

The concept of the Self is one of the most profound and complex ideas in both philosophy and psychology. It is not just about “who we are” on the surface—our name, role, or personality—but about the very essence of our being. To understand the Self deeply, we must look at it from multiple layers: physical, psychological, social, and spiritual.

Concept	Nature	Definition	Status	Source in Indian Thought
Self (Ātman)	Transcendental, eternal	The true self; pure consciousness, unchanging	Real	Upaniṣads, Vedānta, Yoga, Sāṃkhya
Identity	Social, external	Roles, labels, caste, profession, body-related	Illusionary	Karma theory, Ahaṅkāra, Dharma
Self-Concept	Psychological, internal	Self-image; mental evaluation of oneself	Illusionary	Manas, Buddhi, Saṃskāras



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.1

- What word in Indian philosophy describes the psychological knowledge of oneself that is shaped by experiences and desires?
 - Ātman
 - Identity
 - Self-concept
 - Karma

Answer: c

3.4 CONCEPT OF MIND, INTELLECT AND MEMORY

In Indian philosophical psychology, understanding the workings of the self is vital for effective teaching. Ancient Indian thought speaks of the **Antaḥkaraṇa**—the “inner instrument” of consciousness—as composed of four parts:

- **Manas** (मनस्): mind
- **Buddhi** (बुद्धि): intellect
- **Smṛti** (स्मृति): memory
- **Ahaṅkāra** (अहंकार): ego or self-identity

Each of these plays a vital role in how children perceive, learn, reason, remember, and respond. Primary teachers, by recognizing these layers, can design learning experiences that are emotionally grounded, intellectually stimulating, and ethically meaningful (Goswami, 2001).

Different Indian philosophies explain Antaḥkaraṇa in overlapping but unique ways:

1. In Advaita Vedānta, Antaḥkaraṇa is a functional division of the subtle body (*sūkṣmaśarīra*) and consists of four faculties:

- Manas (Mind): deals with doubt, desire, and sensory coordination.
- Buddhi (Intellect): makes judgments and decisions.
- Smṛti (Memory): stores impressions and experiences.
- Ahaṅkāra (Ego): claims ownership—“I am thinking.”

This system helps explain the layered nature of human cognition and supports the idea that educational growth must proceed from *external behaviour* to *inner transformation* (Dasgupta, 1992)

2. Sāṅkhya recognizes three inner faculties as modifications of **Buddhi**:

- *Buddhi* (discriminative faculty)
- *Ahaṅkāra* (ego sense)
- *Manas* (mind)

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In this view, *Buddhi* emerges first from Prakṛti and leads to the evolution of Ahaṅkāra and Manas. Memory (*smṛti*) is seen as a function that arises from the impressions (*saṃskāras*) stored within *manas* and *buddhi* (Raju, 1985).

There are other philosophies too, but without diving deep into others, let's move towards the concept of other faculties of Antahkarna.

3.4.1 Mind

The *manas* is the receptive and processing faculty—engaging with sensory inputs, emotions, and thoughts. In Indian philosophy, particularly in Vedānta and Sāṅkhya systems, *manas* is described as the sensory coordinator and emotional processor. It receives data from the five senses (sight, sound, smell, touch, taste), holds these impressions temporarily, and presents them to the intellect (*buddhi*) for further analysis and decision-making. It is also the seat of desires, doubts, and initial reactions—often functioning rapidly and reactively (Dasgupta, 1992).

According to Nyāya philosophy, *manas* is classified as an internal organ (*antarindriya*), distinct from the external sense organs but essential to cognition. The mind functions as an internal organ that coordinates experience and attention. It is atomic in nature and functions only in contact with one **sense** organ at a time, explaining why human beings can fully attend to only one sensory stream consciously at any moment (Chakrabati, 1999). In this view, *manas* enables attention by selectively channelling experience.

Furthermore, *manas* is considered the starting point of mental activities like imagination, desire, hesitation, and simple memory. It is also closely associated with emotion and mood regulation, as it governs the initial emotional tone of any experience.

- In the primary classroom, this highlights the importance of creating an environment that fosters attentive and calm minds through engaging activities and mindful transitions.

“Just as a mirror needs polishing to reflect clearly, *manas* must be quieted and stabilized to receive and reflect knowledge.”—Paraphrased from *Yoga-Vāsiṣṭha*

Teachers are not merely academic instructors but sculptors of the child's inner instrument. A well-guided *manas* leads to clarity of attention, emotional balance, and readiness to learn.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.2

1. In Indian philosophy, which of the following best sums up the function of *manas*?
 - a) The ultimate source of self-realization and emancipation
 - b) The intellect's capacity for reasoning and decision-making
 - c) The biological organ that processes emotions and takes in sensory information
 - d) The external sense organ in charge of hearing and seeing

Answer: c

3.4.2 Intellect

If *manas* is the mind that gathers sensory input and generates emotions and desires, *buddhi* is the faculty that discerns, reasons, evaluates, and makes decisions. It is the seat of judgment, discrimination (*viveka*), and understanding. In Indian thought—particularly in Vedānta and Sāṅkhya—*buddhi* is considered subtler and more refined than *manas*, capable of guiding action based on reflection, not impulse (Dasgupta, 1992 and Raju, 1985)

In Vedānta, *buddhi* is the aspect of the self that makes meaning, distinguishes between truth and falsehood, and can rise above personal likes and dislikes. It is the beginning of conscience and moral awareness in the developing child. Unlike the reactive nature of *manas*, *buddhi* is deliberate, reflective, and discerning (Paranjpe, 1998). The *buddhi* represents discrimination, reasoning, reflection, and decision-making. It is through *buddhi* that learners analyze, choose, and make moral judgments. (Goswami 2001) notes that the cultivation of intellect is essential for purposeful learning.

Children begin developing *buddhi* gradually—moving from curiosity and mimicry to early reasoning, rule-following, and moral questioning. This makes the primary classroom a critical space for laying the foundations of lifelong thinking skills and value judgment.

In practice, teachers can support *buddhi* development by promoting open-ended questions, simple debates (e.g., “Should we share even when no one sees?”),

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and reflective journaling in child-friendly formats. Teachers must act as guides who nurture the child's ability to pause, think, reflect, and choose. A teacher's questions are often more powerful than their answers in developing *buddhi*.

"Buddhi is the lamp that shows the path. If the lamp is steady and clean, our steps are clear." — Bhagavad Gītā, Ch. 2.41

3.4.3 Memory

Smṛiti is the faculty of remembering—recalling facts, skills, and past experiences that inform current learning. Memory connects prior knowledge with new understanding, forming bridges in the educational journey (Dasgupta, 1992). Smṛti refers to the faculty of memory, not just as the act of recalling facts, but as the ability to retain experiences, form associations, and apply past learning to present situations. It plays a vital role in language learning, habit development, skill formation, and emotional regulation.

In Indian philosophy, particularly in Yoga and Vedānta, smṛti is understood as the residue of past experiences (saṃskāras). These impressions shape how one responds to present reality. Patanjali's Yoga Sūtras describe smṛti as a vṛtti (mental fluctuation) that must be stabilized for self-awareness and learning to occur (Dalal, 2001). Memory is a foundational aspect of early learning, but Indian thought expands it beyond rote learning. Smṛti includes emotional memory, moral memory, and experiential memory—how we store and make meaning of what has happened before. Instructionally, teachers can reinforce smṛiti by using story recalls, thematic song routines, memory games, and linking new lessons to learners' lived experiences. A teacher's role is to curate meaningful experiences and repetition so that memory is not just mechanical but emotionally and morally integrated.

3.4.4 Panch Koshiya Vikas

The concept of Pañchakośa Vikas originates from the Taittirīya-Upaniṣad, one of the foundational texts of Indian spiritual philosophy. The term pañchakośa means "five sheaths" or "five layers," and vikas means "development" or "unfoldment." According to this model, the human being is not limited to the physical body but is composed of five concentric layers, each subtler than the one before: Annamaya (the physical sheath), Prāṇamaya (the vital-energy sheath), Manomaya (the mental-emotional sheath), Vijñānamaya (the intellectual-discriminative sheath), and Ānandamaya (the bliss sheath). These

kośas act as coverings over the innermost reality, the Ātman, or true Self, which is pure consciousness, eternal, and beyond all material attributes. Ancient Indian education placed equal importance on intellectual formation and ethical grounding through *pañchakośa vikas* (Mukhopadhyay, 2001).

Pañchakośa Vikas refers to the systematic development and purification of each of these layers, enabling a person to live a life of balance, clarity, and spiritual growth. It emphasizes that true development is not confined to physical or intellectual achievements alone but involves holistic inner transformation—from bodily health and energy regulation to emotional balance, ethical wisdom, and spiritual joy. Each sheath must be understood, refined, and eventually transcended to reach the core essence of one's being.

This approach integrates yoga, meditation, ethical living, disciplined thinking, and devotional practices, making it a complete and practical framework for self-mastery and liberation (mokṣa). By nurturing all five kośas, an individual aligns their outer life with their inner essence, leading to a fulfilled and awakened existence rooted in the direct experience of the Self. Contemporary Indian psychology acknowledges the importance of indigenous frameworks, such as the kośa model, in educational development (Misra, 2010).



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.3

1. Which of the following statements is correct in light of Pañchakośa Vikas?
 - a) When the physical body is properly cared for, human development is achieved.
 - b) The external layers that divide people from society are known as the five kośas.
 - c) All five sheaths must grow and refine in balance for true development to occur, which results in Self-realization.
 - d) Only intellectual and emotional development is the objective of the pañchakośa concept.

Answer: c

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3.4.5 Panch Koshiya and Holistic Human Development

Holistic human development is an integrated process of nurturing all dimensions of a human being—not just physical or intellectual, but also emotional, moral, social, and spiritual. It aims to shape a well-rounded, balanced, and self-aware person capable of living meaningfully and contributing positively to society.

3.4.5.1 Annamaya Kośa– *The Physical Sheath*

The Annamaya Kośa, the outermost sheath, refers to the physical body, which is formed, sustained, and ultimately dissolved back into food (*anna*). It includes muscles, bones, skin, and all biological systems. This kośa is crucial because it serves as the foundation for all other sheaths—without a healthy body, no higher development is possible. From a spiritual standpoint, however, this body is not the real Self; it is impermanent and subject to birth, decay, and death. Realizing that “I am not this body” is the first step on the path of self-inquiry. Development of this sheath involves healthy diet (*āhāra*), physical activity (*vyāyāma*), yoga *āsanas*, proper rest, and cleanliness. In education, attention to Annamaya Kośa includes physical education, body awareness, hygiene, posture, and movement-based learning to build a strong, balanced foundation for intellectual and emotional growth.

Aspect	Description
Nature	Physical body made of food
Function	Performs all bodily activities
Spiritual View	Gross layer; not the true Self
Development	Nutrition, yoga, hygiene, lifestyle discipline
Educational Role	Physical education, health, sensory learning

3.4.5.2 PrāṇamayaKośa – *The Vital Energy Sheath*

The PrāṇamayaKośa is the sheath composed of life-force energy (*prāṇa*). It governs all physiological functions like respiration, circulation, digestion, and metabolism. It connects the physical body to the mental realm, acting as a bridge between the Annamaya and ManomayaKośas. Spiritually, it represents the flow of life and is more subtle than the body but still not the Self. Disturbances in this sheath can result in fatigue, emotional instability, or illness. Development involves practices like pranayama (breath regulation), energy-balancing techniques, and living in harmony with natural rhythms. In education, fostering this kośa means promoting breathing awareness, vitality, restfulness, and creating

emotionally safe, energetically vibrant learning environments. Activities like nature walks, rhythmic exercises, and deep breathing can support this.

Aspect	Description
Nature	Life-energy, breath, physiological functions
Function	Powers bodily and mental activity
Spiritual View	Subtle but impermanent
Development	Pranayama, balanced living, energy awareness
Educational Role	Breathing exercises, vitality-building, energetic classroom environment

3.4.5.3 ManomayaKośa – The Mental-Emotional Sheath

The ManomayaKośa encompasses the mind, emotions, desires, and sensory impressions. It is the seat of manas (the reactive mind) and works in coordination with the senses (*indriyas*). This sheath determines how we emotionally respond to situations and how we form early attitudes and mental habits. Spiritually, it is still within the realm of illusion (*māyā*), as it fluctuates constantly and is often clouded by likes and dislikes (*rāga-dveṣa*). Purification involves practices like mindfulness, emotional regulation, mantra chanting, and *bhakti* (devotional practices). In education, this kośa is addressed through emotional intelligence training, social-emotional learning, nurturing creativity, storytelling, empathetic teaching methods, and creating psychologically safe spaces where students feel seen and heard.

Aspect	Description
Nature	Mind, emotions, sensory perceptions
Function	Emotional response, memory, reactive thought
Spiritual View	Transient and bound by desire
Development	Emotional regulation, chanting, arts, devotion
Educational Role	SEL (Social Emotional Learning), mental health, creativity, empathy

3.4.5.4 VijñānamayaKośa – The Intellectual and Wisdom Sheath

The VijñānamayaKośa is the sheath of intellect (*buddhi*), reason, discernment, and higher knowledge. It is responsible for making decisions, forming values, and distinguishing right from wrong. Spiritually, this sheath is more refined and closely linked to self-awareness and ethical understanding, yet it still does not represent the ultimate Self because it is shaped by conditioning and limited cognition. Its purification involves self-inquiry, critical reflection, ethical living,

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and scriptural study (*svādhyāya*). In education, this is the level that aligns most with traditional academic goals—developing thinking skills, moral reasoning, ethical sensitivity, and the ability to reflect and self-assess. Teachers should cultivate value education, questioning, debate, logic, and reflective writing.

Aspect	Description
Nature	Intellect, wisdom, conscience
Function	Decision-making, discernment, inner knowing
Spiritual View	Subtle, closer to Self, but still not final reality
Development	Scriptural study, contemplation, ethical practice
Educational Role	Critical thinking, moral education, values, self-reflection

3.4.5.5 ĀnandamayaKośa – The Bliss Sheath

The ĀnandamayaKośa is the innermost sheath, closest to the Self, and is experienced as bliss, deep joy, peace, or fulfilment. It is not permanent bliss, but rather a reflection of the Ātman's presence in the subtle body. This state is temporarily touched during deep meditation, selfless service, devotion, or deep sleep, but it is not the ultimate Self itself. Spiritual disciplines aim to stabilize this bliss and pierce through it to realize the non-dual Ātman beyond all experience. Development of this kośa includes meditation, silence, gratitude, and acts of unconditional love. In education, nurturing this layer involves cultivating inner joy, flow experiences, purposeful learning, and exposure to aesthetic, spiritual, or meditative activities that evoke inner peace and deeper connection.

Aspect	Description
Nature	Bliss, inner joy, peace, love
Function	Provides deep contentment and purpose
Spiritual View	Most refined layer; reflection of Ātman, but not Ātman itself
Development	Meditation, love, gratitude, contemplation
Educational Role	Purposeful learning, peace education, meditative experiences

The Panchkoshiya Vyavastha is not merely a philosophical model but a practical roadmap for holistic human development. It addresses the entire spectrum of human life—from the body to the spirit. When integrated into modern education, healthcare, and personal practices, it nurtures balanced, aware, and fulfilled individuals, which ultimately contributes to a healthier and more compassionate society.

3.4.6 Panchkoshiya Vikas and its Educational Implications

The five koshas support each other and lay strong foundational bases for life. Now let's see why Panchakosha is crucial for primary education.

Children in the pre-primary years are like soft clay—impressionable and full of potential, ready to be shaped for the future. However, most traditional education systems tend to focus solely on academics, often overlooking essential aspects such as emotional development, physical health, and creative expression. As a result, many crucial dimensions of a child's holistic growth are left undernourished.

In modern education, especially in child development, we focus on building confidence, motivation, and positive identity. These are important. But integrating deeper views of the Self—such as the observer within, the interconnected self, or the spiritual self—can help children:

- Develop inner strength in times of stress.
- Understand that they are more than their failures or labels.
- Practice self-awareness, which supports emotional regulation.
- Feel connected to others and the larger world.
- Develop a sense of purpose beyond personal success.

As teachers and caregivers, recognizing the layers of the Self helps us nurture whole children—not just minds, but minds with awareness, hearts with empathy, and spirits with depth.

1. Annamaya Kosha: The Physical Layer

Why does it matter?

A child's physical health forms the essential foundation for all other aspects of development. When children are healthy and physically active, they are more attentive, emotionally stable, and ready to engage with learning. In contrast, poor physical well-being can negatively impact concentration, motivation, and emotional regulation.

How to Support it at Foundational and Preparatory Stage

To nurture this foundational layer, schools should thoughtfully incorporate

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physical activity and care into the daily routine. This can include simple yoga exercises or stretching routines that promote flexibility and calmness, alongside playful games like hopscotch, crawling through tunnels, or walking along balance beams to develop motor skills. Providing nutritious snacks or mid-day meals also ensures that children's bodies are fuelled for sustained energy and healthy growth.

Classroom Activities for empowering Annamaya Kosha:

1. Teacher may start class with light stretching and Yog Asanas by introducing the importance of Healthy Body.
2. Hygiene education may be included through posters, stories and activities.
3. Teacher may encourage "body scans" – simple awareness of posture, tension, and breath.
4. Talk about different emotions and how they can affect how the body feels and vice versa.

2. Pranamaya Kosha: The Energy Layer

Why does it matter?

Young children are naturally full of energy, but without proper direction, this vitality can become unfocused, leading to restlessness and difficulty in concentrating. When guided and balanced, however, this energy becomes a powerful force that enhances emotional stability, attentiveness, and joyful participation in learning activities.

How to Support it at Foundational and Preparatory Stage

Supporting this layer involves helping children learn to regulate and channel their energy in constructive ways. Simple breathing exercises, such as "balloon breathing," can teach self-regulation and promote calm. Outdoor play—including running, skipping, or nature-based exploration—offers a healthy outlet for physical energy. To balance activity with stillness, educators can also introduce short mindfulness practices or quiet time to help children reset and develop inner calm.

Classroom Activities for empowering Pranamaya Kosha:

1. Teacher may ask students to describe their energy level (e.g., full, low, jittery) and relate it to their breath before proceeding in the class.
2. Before starting session of the class, teacher may ask students to take pause and take three mindful and slow breaths while chanting 'ॐ' in their minds.
3. Take students outside for a short silent walk. Guide them to match steps with breath or observe the breath while walking.
4. Simple pranayama techniques like Anulom-Vilom, Surya Kriya etc, can be inculcated within the class either before the session or in-between the classroom sessions.
5. Teacher may combine slow body movements (like raising arms or walking in place) with conscious breathing patterns.

3. Manomaya Kosha: The Mental and Emotional Layer

Why does it matter?

In early childhood, learning extends far beyond academic concepts like letters and numbers. This stage is critical for the development of Emotional Intelligence (EQ), where children begin to understand and manage their feelings, navigate frustration, and form meaningful social connections. These early emotional experiences lay the foundation for how children will relate to themselves and others throughout their lives.

How to Support it at Foundational and Preparatory Stage

Educators can support this emotional layer by integrating practices that promote empathy, self-awareness, and communication. Storytelling sessions that explore characters' emotions, paired with reflective questions like "How do you think the character feels?", help children recognize and articulate feelings. Role-play and pretend play provide opportunities to practice empathy and cooperation in imaginative ways. Daily circle time also serves as a safe, nurturing space for children to express their thoughts and emotions, fostering a sense of trust, belonging, and emotional safety.

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Classroom Activities empowering Manomaya Kosa:

1. Tell a story (myth, parable, or real-life story) and discuss how characters felt and responded.
2. Ask students to draw or paint how they feel, or represent an emotion (like joy, fear, or peace) visually.
3. Give students a situation or tell them a story and ask them list the thought it triggered, the emotion they felt, and how they responded.
4. Ask students for regular journaling about feelings, experiences, or things they are thankful for.
5. Ask students to act out different emotions or problem-solving scenarios.

4. Vijñanamaya Kosha: The Intellectual Layer

Why does it matter?

Curiosity is the driving force behind all meaningful learning. In early childhood, children are natural explorers, eager to make sense of the world around them. Nurturing this kosha supports the development of both analytical thinking and creative problem-solving, laying the foundation for lifelong learning.

How to Support it at Foundational and Preparatory Stage

To engage this intellectual layer, educators can provide hands-on, playful learning experiences such as building blocks, jigsaw puzzles, or sorting games that challenge thinking and promote discovery. Asking open-ended questions like “What do you think will happen next?” encourages children to think critically and make predictions. Thematic learning—integrating subjects through topics like animals, seasons, or transport using songs, stories, and art—creates a rich, immersive environment that stimulates cognitive engagement and deeper understanding.

Classroom Activities empowering VijñanamayaKosha:

1. Present students with real-life or hypothetical ethical dilemmas (e.g., “Should we always respect elders, even if they seem unfair?”).
2. Begin or end class with 2–5 minutes of silence followed by one reflection question (e.g., “Did I act from my best self today?”, “Did I do something Brave?”).

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3. Pose open-ended, thought-provoking questions (e.g., “Can rules ever be broken?”) and allow student-led inquiry.
4. Start a short story and let students finish it in drawing or writing for ethical reflection.
5. Pose simple dilemmas (e.g., telling the truth vs. avoiding trouble) and ask students to think alone, then discuss in pairs, and finally share with the class.

5. Anandamaya Kosha: The Blissful Layer

Why does it matter?

Children thrive when they are happy. Joyful learning creates lasting positive memories and lays the foundation for a lifelong love of learning. A happy child is more open, curious, and emotionally secure.

How to Nurture it at Foundational and Preparatory Stage

Fostering this layer begins by celebrating creativity in every form—through activities like painting, dancing, and singing, children can express themselves freely and joyfully. Encouraging gratitude, such as asking each child to share something they’re thankful for, helps cultivate a positive and reflective mindset. Additionally, creating a warm, inclusive, and appreciative classroom environment ensures every child feels valued, safe, and loved.

3.5 DEVELOPMENT OF SELF IN RELATION TO INDIAN SOCIETY

Indian spiritual traditions offer a profound perspective on the nature of the self, one that goes far beyond everyday experiences of the waking state. According to the wisdom of ancient sages—rishis, yogis, siddhas, and other spiritual seekers—the waking state (jāgrat) represents only one layer of human consciousness. Through intense inner discipline, meditative practices, and the path of yoga, they discovered that human experience is not bound by the limits of time and space. At the core of every individual lies a spiritual essence—*Ātman*—which transcends physical form, thoughts, and social roles. This deeper self is distinct from the bio-psycho-social identity most people associate with themselves in daily life.

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To move from a limited sense of identity to the realization of this true, transcendental self, two key inner processes are emphasized in Indian philosophy. The first is *Viveka*, or discrimination—the ability to clearly distinguish between the temporary and ever-changing outer self (body, mind, emotions, and societal roles) and the eternal, unchanging inner self rooted in pure awareness. The second is *Vairāgya*, or detachment—a conscious process of dis-identifying from material and social attachments, allowing the seeker to gradually move inward. Without developing detachment from the external world, the experience of pure consciousness remains inaccessible, as one remains entangled in the routines of ordinary life.

To support this journey toward self-realization, Indian philosophy outlines a four-stage life model known as *Ashrama Dharma*. The first stage, *Brahmacharya* (student life), focuses on learning, self-discipline, and character-building. The second, *Gārhastya* (householder), involves fulfilling responsibilities related to family, career, and social roles. These two stages are seen as important for building the bio-psycho-social identity. The third stage, *Vānaprastha* (retirement), marks a gradual withdrawal from worldly life and a turn toward inner reflection. Finally, the stage of *Sanyāsa* (renunciation) is dedicated to the full inward journey of spiritual pursuit and realization of the true self.

While not everyone follows these stages strictly, the model provides a universal and holistic framework for human development. It acknowledges the need to fulfil worldly duties before progressing toward spiritual awakening and ultimately discovering one's true identity beyond the material world.



3.6 LET US SUM UP

This chapter explores the rich Indian philosophical and psychological perspectives on the Self, offering a multidimensional understanding essential for holistic human development. It distinguishes between *Self* (Ātman), *identity*, and *self-concept*, highlighting that while identity and self-concept are shaped by external and internal experiences, the Ātman is the eternal, unchanging core of consciousness. Through the lens of the *Pañchakośa* model—Annamaya, Prāṇamaya, Manomaya, Vijñānamaya, and Ānandamayakośas—it presents a layered view of human existence, showing how development across physical, energetic, emotional, intellectual, and blissful dimensions leads to inner balance and self-realization. These ideas have practical implications in early

childhood education, where nurturing all five layers helps foster physical health, emotional intelligence, creativity, curiosity, and joy. The Indian societal model of *Āśrama Dharma* further supports this journey, emphasizing learning, ethical living, detachment, and eventual spiritual awakening. Integrating these insights into educational and developmental frameworks nurtures whole individuals—physically strong, mentally resilient, ethically grounded, and spiritually aware.



3.7 END EXERCISES

1. Distinguish the terms self, identity, and self-concept.
2. Differentiate between the concept of Mind, Intellect, Memory and Ahamkara.
3. Elaborate the importance of Four Stage Model in Indian Society for holistic development.
4. Describe the importance of educational implications of Panckoshiya Vyavastha.
5. Describe 'Tatvamasi' in your own words.
6. Why is it important for a teacher to understand the Panchkoshiya Vyavastha?
7. What is the Prāṇamaya Kośa and how is it different from the Annamaya Kośa?
8. How does prāṇa influence bodily functions like breathing and digestion?
9. What is 'manas', and how does it differ from deeper aspects of the mind like intellect or intuition?
10. What is the *Ānandamaya Kośa*, and how is it different from the other four sheaths in the human personality model?
11. Why is it important for teachers to address not just intellectual or ethical development (e.g., *Vijñānamaya Kośa*), but also inner joy and emotional-spiritual well-being?

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Notes

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3.8 REFERENCES

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